

KITCHEN THREE

METHOD CREATES DISTINCTION

GUIDE 02 · BRANDING

Food Brand Identity — *from name to plate*

Every choice a customer notices is brand: the name on the door, the spoon in their hand, the photograph on the app, the line on the receipt. A practical guide to making those choices on purpose, not by default.

A food brand is not a *logo*.

A logo is one of two hundred decisions that build a brand. The other hundred and ninety-nine are the ones most operators get wrong — because nobody told them they were brand decisions.

When someone walks past your café and looks at the sign, they are reading the brand. When they take the first sip of coffee, they are reading the brand. When they pick up a takeaway bag and feel its weight, when they unfold a napkin, when they see the way you photographed the pasta, when they read your menu's dish names — they are reading the brand.

The brand is the cumulative impression of every touchpoint. Get a few of them right and you have a coherent business. Get many of them right and you have something customers tell their friends about.

This guide walks through the seven main territories where brand is built or lost in food: naming, visual identity, packaging, menu, plateware, food theater, and consistency across channels. It is opinionated rather than exhaustive — these are the calls we make for clients, and the reasoning behind them.

Customers do not remember your tagline. They remember whether the bag was clean, the spoon was heavy, and the music was right. Build the brand at the points the customer actually touches.

— KITCHEN THREE PRINCIPLE

The *name*.

The first decision and the hardest one to change later. Get it wrong and you will pay for it forever in friction.

1. What a good food name does

- **Pronounces easily** — for both Egyptian Arabic and English speakers if you serve both
- **Visualises easily** — the customer can describe it on the phone and the friend can find it
- **Suggests a direction** — without locking you in. "Burger King" describes the category and the positioning; "Sea Queen" gives you a feeling without telling you the menu
- **Has dot-com and Instagram handle availability** — non-negotiable in 2026
- **Survives translation** — both Arabic transliteration and English back-translation should be neutral or positive

2. The traps

- ☐ Founder names — only work if the founder has earned the name commercially before the restaurant opens
- ☐ Geographic names — "Italia," "Napoli," "Damascus" — overcrowded and forgettable; pick a specific neighbourhood instead
- ☐ Punny names — "Pita Pan," "Lord of the Wings" — read as cheap; cannot be raised in tier later
- ☐ Generic words — "The Kitchen," "The Bistro" — impossible to claim search results and harder to brand
- ☐ Names with unusual spellings — every order, every reservation, every social tag is a fight

3. The Arabic/English duality

In Egypt the brand will live in both scripts. Decide which is primary and which is secondary, and design the relationship between them:

- **English-primary brands** typically have a small Arabic transliteration underneath the main logotype. Common for premium and international-leaning concepts.
- **Arabic-primary brands** work brilliantly when the concept leans local. The Arabic typography becomes the signature — done well, it cannot be replicated by generic competitors. Sea Queen and Mori Sushi pull this off in opposite directions.

- **Bilingual logotypes** require a designer who can letter both scripts to the same visual weight. Most Egyptian F&B logos fail this test — the English looks like it was made by a typographer and the Arabic looks like it was made by an afterthought.

A NAME YOU ACTUALLY OWN

Run the name through: USPTO trademark search, the Egyptian Trademark Office, Instagram handle, .com domain, and Google's first page. If any of these belongs to a same-category business, walk away. The legal cost of fighting a parallel name is always more than the marketing cost of choosing a different one.

Logo, palette, *typography*.

Three pillars. Most operators commission a logo and stop there. The logo is the smallest of the three.

1. Logo

A good food logo works in four sizes — Instagram profile photo (small circle, no detail), printed menu (medium, full detail), packaging (varied — from a 4cm coffee cup to a 30cm takeaway bag), and signage (large, viewed from distance, often at angle). Many logos look great in the designer's deck and fail at one of these.

Test the logo in actual use before signing off. Print it. Stick it on a coffee cup. Photograph it under the lighting your café will use. If it fails any of the four sizes, it isn't done.

2. Palette

A working food palette has 3–5 colours. More than that and consistency breaks within six months. Less than that and the brand looks underbaked. The relationships matter more than the colours themselves:

- One dominant — the primary brand colour, used on 60–70% of brand touchpoints
- One secondary — a supporting colour used on 20–30%
- One or two accents — used sparingly on specific elements (CTAs, callouts, special items)
- A neutral base — usually a warm off-white or near-black, depending on whether the brand is light or dark

For F&B specifically: avoid pure white (looks clinical, photographs cold), pure black (looks heavy, photographs lifeless), and primary blue (very few foods are blue — the colour reads "not food" to customers). Earth tones, warm whites, and saturated accents tend to work hardest.

3. Typography

One pairing — one display face and one body face — is the standard. Two pairings, used consistently across primary and secondary contexts, is the maximum.

- **Display face** — sets the brand's voice. Serif faces (Cormorant Garamond, Garamond, Tisa) read editorial and premium. Geometric sans (DM Sans, Inter, Söhne) read modern and direct. Slab serif (Roboto Slab, Source Serif) reads sturdy and confident. Custom hand-lettering reads artisan and small-batch.

- **Body face** — should be unobtrusive and legible at all sizes. Almost always a humanist sans for body in 2026 (DM Sans, Inter, Source Sans).
- **Arabic typeface** — needs to match the visual weight and feeling of your Latin typeface. Cocomat, Tasees, GE SS Two, and 29LT's family are the common high-quality choices. Choose carefully; mismatched Arabic ruins otherwise good identities.

CONSISTENCY BEATS CLEVERNESS

A modest identity used consistently for two years outperforms a brilliant identity used inconsistently for two months. Brand recognition compounds. Every printed menu, every package, every social post that uses the system reinforces it. Inconsistency resets the counter.

Packaging as *brand carrier*.

In a delivery-led market, packaging is the most physically present brand experience the customer has. Most F&B operations treat it as a commodity. That's the gap.

1. Functional first

No amount of branding fixes packaging that leaks, soggs, or arrives cold. Test every container with the actual food for the actual delivery time before printing thousands. Specifically check:

- ☐ Containers hold the food at temperature for 30 minutes minimum
- ☐ Sauces stay in their sections — no migration
- ☐ Sealed lids don't pop under pressure changes (cars, AC, elevators)
- ☐ Hot and cold items in the same order do not affect each other
- ☐ The bag holds shape with the food in it — not just the empty bag

2. Then branded

- ☐ Brand-printed bags, even one-colour, beat generic kraft bags by a wide margin in perceived value
- ☐ Sticker seals — economical way to brand otherwise generic containers, and they double as tamper-evident
- ☐ Custom-printed napkins are an inexpensive luxury signal
- ☐ One inserted item — recipe card, brand story card, dessert flyer — turns the box into a marketing touchpoint
- ☐ Sauces in branded mini-jars, not plastic packets — instant tier signal

3. The unboxing moment

Imagine the customer opening the bag at home. What is the order of reveal? What is the first thing they see? What is the last? Sequence the unboxing on purpose: bag open, branded paper or insert visible first, then containers, then the food inside. Each layer is a chance to confirm the customer made a good choice.

SUSTAINABILITY AND BRAND

Customers in the upper Cairo and New Cairo markets increasingly read packaging as a sustainability signal. Branded recyclable / compostable packaging is more expensive — and increasingly worth it for premium concepts. The savings on Styrofoam are smaller than the brand cost of being seen as careless.

The menu *as object*.

A menu is brand made tangible. The single piece of marketing material every paying customer holds in their hand.

1. Physical menu (dine-in)

- ☐ Paper weight — 250+ gsm reads premium; flimsy menus undercut the food before it arrives
- ☐ Format — single-fold, bifold, trifold, or board; pick one and stick with it across iterations
- ☐ Dish photography — either go all-photo or zero-photo; partial photography (some dishes with photos, others without) cheapens the whole menu
- ☐ Section structure — typically 4–6 sections; more and the menu reads bloated; less and it reads thin
- ☐ Dish names — characterful but not opaque; "Suzukake" needs a parenthetical; "Black sesame ice cream" does not

2. Digital menu (delivery apps)

- ☐ Every dish has a photograph — non-photo dishes get 60–70% fewer orders on the apps
- ☐ Consistent photography style — same lighting, same angle, same background — across all photos
- ☐ Dish descriptions written for someone scrolling at speed — 1 to 2 short sensory phrases, not a paragraph
- ☐ Categories on the apps follow the customer's mental model, not your kitchen's organisation
- ☐ Featured / bestseller flags used sparingly to direct the order

3. Voice and copy

The brand voice should sound the same on the menu, the Instagram caption, the receipt, the email signature, and the WhatsApp reply. Define it explicitly: three adjectives, two sample dishes named, three voice rules ("never use exclamation marks", "always use British spelling", "never apologise for menu changes"). Document it. Train staff to use it. The result is a brand that feels like one person, not a committee.

The customer notices first the things you tried hardest to hide — the brand inconsistencies. Customers are pattern-matchers. Every unmatched moment costs trust.

— KITCHEN THREE OBSERVATION

Plateware, environment, *food theater*.

The final layer of brand — the things the customer interacts with directly. Skipped most often. Worth the most.

1. Plateware

The plate, bowl, cup, and cutlery the customer holds is brand at its most intimate. Mass-produced white china is the equivalent of using a generic font everywhere — competent, characterless. A signature plateware choice — handmade pottery, a specific cup shape, an unusual cutlery weight — becomes the brand's tactile signature.

For cloud kitchens, plateware substitutes are the takeaway containers, the cutlery in the bag, the cup of a coffee delivery. The same principle applies: a branded wooden spoon in a bowl of ramen says more than five Instagram posts.

2. Environment (dine-in concepts)

- ☐ Lighting — warm, dimmer than the customer's home; never overhead fluorescent in food spaces
- ☐ Music — curated playlist, not shuffle; volume adjusts through service (louder at peak, softer at close)
- ☐ Scent — the smell of food should dominate; no perfume diffusers, no harsh cleaning smells during service
- ☐ Temperature — slightly cool is luxury; slightly warm is fatigue; the difference is 2 degrees
- ☐ Furniture comfort — guests who are physically uncomfortable leave faster and tip less

3. Food theater

The visible moments where the food is being prepared, finished, or presented — open kitchens, finishing stations, table-side service, the way dishes are walked to the table. Done deliberately, these moments are unpaid advertising. Done absently, they are silent. The choice is whether to design them on purpose.

4. Consistency across channels

The customer who orders delivery on Monday, walks in for lunch on Wednesday, and follows you on Instagram on Friday should be experiencing the same brand. The most common failure mode in

Egyptian F&B: a beautiful dine-in concept whose Instagram looks like a different business, whose delivery app photos look like a third business, and whose packaging looks like a fourth. Each gap costs a small amount of trust. They compound.

A WORKING TEST

Photograph six things in your operation: the front signage, the menu, the plate as served, the takeaway bag at handover, the Instagram feed, and the delivery-app listing. Lay all six side by side. Could a stranger tell they belong to the same business in one glance? If yes — the brand is working. If no — the work is to close the gap.

Ready to *build*?

Kitchen Three's design practice has built brand identity systems for restaurants, cloud kitchens, packaged-food brands, hotel F&B departments, and culinary schools across Egypt. We work upstream — naming, identity, packaging, menu design, plateware, food theater — before the kitchen opens. Talk to us about your concept.

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